Youth Run NOLA: Where the Finish Line Is Just the Beginning

youthrunnola.org

This interview was conducted with Jon Lee, Executive Director, and Brenna Byrne, Program Director of Youth Run NOLA.

Youth Run NOLA (YRN) has been building healthier and more interconnected communities throughout the city of New Orleans since 2010, with its no-cost, fun, and inclusive running programs for young people ages 8-20. What began with a group of dedicated educators running alongside students after school has transformed into a community-rooted nonprofit that has remained true to its vision. That vision was simple: empowering young individuals through the unifying power of running.

YRN partners with both schools and community sites across St. Bernard, Orleans, and Jefferson Parishes. YRN's non-competitive program prioritizes team-building through both sprint and distance workouts, highlighting the importance of running literacy, while also teaching the fundamentals of anatomy. Youth Run NOLA seeks to provide its program participants with a sense of self-determination and a belief in limitless possibilities. Its leaders and participants are shaping New Orleans' next generation of empowered communities through healthier lifestyles and joyful experiences.

YRN's commitment is further demonstrated by its results, which include assisting 270 youth in completing half-marathons, employing 17 YRN alumni as paid part-time staff, and the contribution of more than 46,000 volunteer hours.

Q: Twenty years after Katrina, what does Youth Run NOLA's existence say about New Orleans' resilience and the community's ability to rebuild on its own terms?

Brenna Byrne: "Katrina severely messed up the locals' access to their own youth. So to be able to have this space and to really see a lot of family members coming in and stepping up, siblings and youth that are now learning how to be leaders—it's like everyone is helping pull each other up. Giving all the kids who are from here the best opportunity they can to really own their city again. They have the skills, the community, and the network to be able to succeed in a city that has been really taken over by transplants and people who don't know the culture."

Q: Katrina displaced so many families and disrupted entire communities. How does your work help repair or strengthen what was lost?

BB: "This year, we're seeing a lot of schools being closed down, and it's just horrible. It's really digging into the culture here of pride in their high school. A lot of our kids don't even have a high school anymore that they graduated from, but they do come back here, and this feels more like homecoming. They know when they come to Youth Run, they know they're going to know people, and they're going to have a good time. So, it's like home for a lot of people."

Q: What's the hardest thing your organization has overcome, and what did getting through it teach you?

Jon Lee: "One of the hardest things our organization has been navigating is the landscape of schools right now (school closures). Again, so many of our young people, one of the places that they call home is being taken away. So for us, we want to ensure that we continue to provide those spaces for them to excel in education, excel in community. It's on us to ensure that we continue to provide those resources and that community aspect, so it doesn't shift too much of what's already changing in their everyday lives."

Q: If the people you serve could speak directly to the donors, partners, and supporters who make your work possible, what do you think they would say?

BB: "It's so hard to describe what it takes to work at a small nonprofit because you're doing every single job. We are the media people, graphics, communications. We're running the route before and marking it. I'm recruiting all the volunteers. Every single little detail you would have never thought about is on just the three or four of us. We do a lot with a little. We're just so grateful anytime that people want to fund our activities and that they believe in this program, because a little bit of money goes a long way for us."

JL: Youth Run NOLA is so much more than just a running program. Sometimes people hear the name, and they think it's just about running, but it's the social-emotional learning, it's the curriculum, and just a community that supports the young people throughout school and connects them to education even beyond school. We really strive to ensure that our program remains cost-free. It definitely takes resources and money to ensure that we continue to provide this experience at no cost—that's something that we won't waver on.

Q: When you think about the next 20 years, what role do you see Youth Run NOLA playing in the continued recovery and reimaging of New Orleans?

JL: "Twenty years from now, I'm hoping that the impact that we have on the young people is when they have their families or their closest network, they continue to bring them to Youth Run NOLA. And that we continue to change the narrative of what health looks and feels like. Again, at Youth Run, we always say, 'You can run, walk, jog, just show up and have fun with the community.' You decide what your activity looks like. So, twenty years from now, the goal is that Youth Run NOLA is still a place, a community of support for whatever your health journey is."

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Your support makes this work possible. A gift of any size helps Youth Run NOLA continue serving the community and building a stronger, more resilient city for everyone.

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